What Is the Horror Genre?

Literary Criticism by **Sharon A. Russell**

In what ways are horror stories defined and categorized? This author tries to pin down the genre.

1 Many people define horror by its subjects. We all think of creatures like Frankenstein's monster, Dracula, and the wolfman[1] as monsters in the horror genre. Each one of these creatures has a history and developed over a period of time. But we also know that horror covers more than just these monsters. We could all make long lists of the kind of creatures we identify with horror, especially when we think of films as well as literature. The minute we would start to make such a list we would also realize that not all monsters are alike and that not all horror deals with monsters. The subject approach is not the clearest way to define this genre.

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Text in Focus Video

Learn more about understanding the horror genre.

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Close Read Screencast

Listen to a modeled close read of this text.

[1] **Frankenstein's monster, Dracula, and the wolfman:** legendary monsters. "Frankenstein's monster" is the creature created by Dr. Victor Frankenstein in Mary Shelley's novel; "Dracula" is the vampire in Bram Stoker's novel; in folklore, the wolfman is a man who can become a wolf.

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NOTICE & NOTE
QUOTED WORDS

When you notice the author citing other people to provide support for a point, you've found a **Quoted Words** signpost.

Notice & Note: Mark where Russell uses quoted words in paragraph 2.

Analyze: Why was this quotation included, and what does this add?

intensify
(ĭn-tĕn´sə-fī´) *v*. If you *intensify* something, you make it grow in strength.

justify
(jŭs´tə-fī´) *v*. If you *justify* something, you prove it is right or valid.

2 Some students of this genre find that the best way to examine it is to deal with the way horror fiction is organized or structured. Examining the organization of a horror story shows that it shares certain traits with other types of fiction. Horror stories share the use of suspense as a tactic with many other kinds of literature. The tension we feel when a character goes into the attic, down into the basement, or just into the abandoned house is partially a result of suspense. We don't know what is going to happen. But that suspense is **intensified** by our knowledge of the genre. We know that characters involved in the world of horror always meet something awful when they go where they shouldn't. Part of the tension is created because they are doing something we know is going to get them in trouble. Stephen King refers directly to our anticipation of horror. In *Salem's Lot*[2] Susan approaches the house which is the source of evil. "She found herself thinking of those drive-in horror movie epics where the heroine goes venturing up the narrow attic stairs . . . or down into some dark, cobwebby cellar . . . and she . . . thinking: . . . *I'd never do that!*" Of course Susan's fears are **justified**. She does end up dead in the basement, a victim of the vampire.

3 If the horror genre uses the character's search for information to create suspense, it controls when and where we get our knowledge. Because we are outside of the situation we usually know more than the characters. Our advance knowledge creates suspense because we can anticipate what is going to happen. The author can play with those expectations by either confirming them or surprising us with a different outcome. When suspense is an important element in fiction we may often find that the plot is the most critical part of the story. We care more about what happens next than about who the characters are or where the story is set. But setting is often considered a part of the horror genre. If the genre has traditional monsters, it also has traditional settings. Only authors who want to challenge the tradition place events in bright, beautiful parks. We expect a connection between the setting and the events in this genre. We are not surprised to find old houses, abandoned castles, damp cellars, or dark forests as important elements in the horror story.

4 Some people make further distinctions based on how the stories are organized. We can divide stories into different categories based on how we come to believe in the events related and how they are explained to us. Stories that deal with

[2] ***Salem's Lot:*** a horror fiction novel written by Stephen King.

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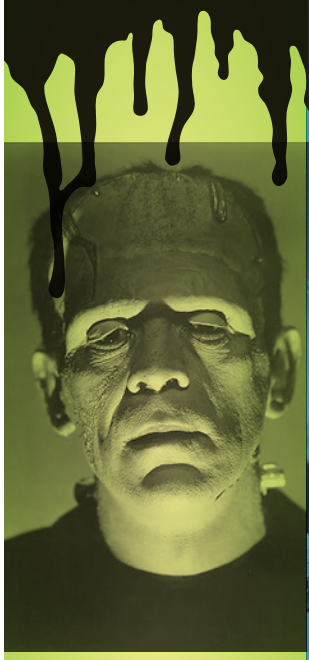
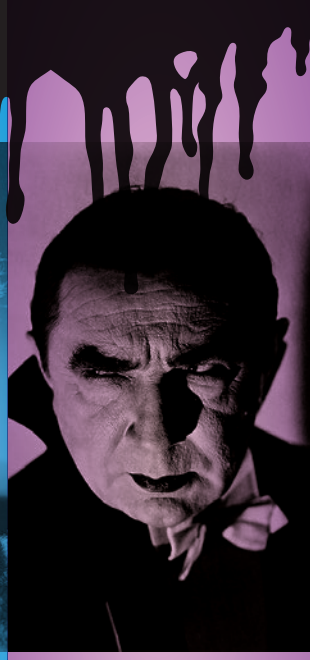


The actor Boris Karloff as the monster in the 1931 film *Frankenstein,* based on the novel

The actor Lon Chaney as a werewolf in the 1941 film *The Wolf Man*



The actor Bela Lugosi as Dracula in the 1931 film by the same name

Don't forget to **Notice & Note** as you read the text.

parallel worlds expect us to accept those worlds without question. We just believe Dorothy is in Oz; we accept Oz as a parallel world separate from ours. Other times events seem to be supernatural but turn out to have natural explanations: the ghosts turn out to be squirrels in the attic, or things that move mysteriously are part of a plot to drive someone crazy. Sometimes the supernatural is the result of the way the central character sees the world, as in stories told from the point of view of a crazy person. But at times we are not sure, and hesitate about believing in the possibility of the supernatural. When I first read Dracula I seriously considered hanging garlic on my windows because I believed that vampires could exist. This type of hesitation, when we almost believe, falls into the general category of the "fantastic" (Todorov 25).[3] Often horror has its greatest effect on us because we almost believe, or believe while we are reading the book or watching the film, that the events are possible.

5 Yet another way of categorizing works of horror is by the source of the horror. Some horror comes from inside the characters. Something goes wrong inside, and a person turns into a monster. Dr. Frankenstein's need for knowledge turns him into the kind of person who creates a monster. Dr. Jekyll

parallel
(păr´ə-lĕl´) *adj.* If things are *parallel,* they have comparable or similar parts.

ANALYZE LITERARY CRITICISM

Annotate: Mark the sentence that states the main idea of paragraph 4.

Analyze: How does the main idea of paragraph 4 contribute to the development of the central ideas of the text?

[3] **Todorov 25:** The author is following MLA style to cite her source for the information just stated: page 25 of a work by an author named Todorov.

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also values his desire for information above all else, and creates Mr. Hyde.[4] In another kind of horror story the threat to the central character or characters comes from outside. An outside force may invade the character and then force the evil out again. The vampire attacks the victim, but then the victim becomes a vampire and attacks others. Stories of ghosts or demonic possession also fall into this category.

6 We can also look at the kinds of themes common to horror. Many works concentrate on the conflict between good and evil. Works about the fantastic may deal with the search for forbidden knowledge that appears in much horror literature. Such quests are used as a way of examining our attitude toward knowledge. While society may believe that new knowledge is always good, the horror genre may question this assumption, examining how such advances affect the individual and society.

PARAPHRASE AND SUMMARIZE TEXT

Annotate: Underline a challenging sentence in paragraph 6. Circle words in the sentence that could be replaced with simpler ones.

Paraphrase: Restate the sentence in your own words.

[4] **Dr. Jekyll . . . and . . . Mr. Hyde:** the good and evil sides of the same character in a novella by Robert Louis Stevenson.

ESSENTIAL QUESTION:
Why do we sometimes like to feel frightened?

Review your notes and add your thoughts to your Response Log.

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